

From Objective Character Motivation to Learners’ Subjective Reconstruction

A Pilot Study on Conceptual Mapping in the Rén Component Family among Spanish-Speaking Learners of Chinese

GAO Zhenyu
gaozhenyu@usal.es

Is the Rén component family visually transparent, or cognitively reconstructible?

The Rén component family is historically motivated by the graphic representation of the human figure, but this motivation is not necessarily perceived directly by Spanish-speaking learners.

Research problem

Objective character motivation ≠ learner interpretation

Historical accounts explain the Rén component family through character structure, etymology, and form–meaning relations. However, learner responses show that this objective motivation does not automatically become learner-perceived motivation.

The issue is not only what these characters historically represent, but how Spanish-speaking learners interpret them, extract visual cues, activate associations, and construct subjective rationales from graphic form.

Pilot study

- **Participants:** 9 Spanish-speaking learners of Chinese
- **Learning background:** approximately 4 months
- **Task:** open-ended interpretation and association of character forms
- **Focus:** the character 人 rén and its component family
- **Data:** exploratory questionnaire responses
- **Analysis:** inductive coding of learner responses

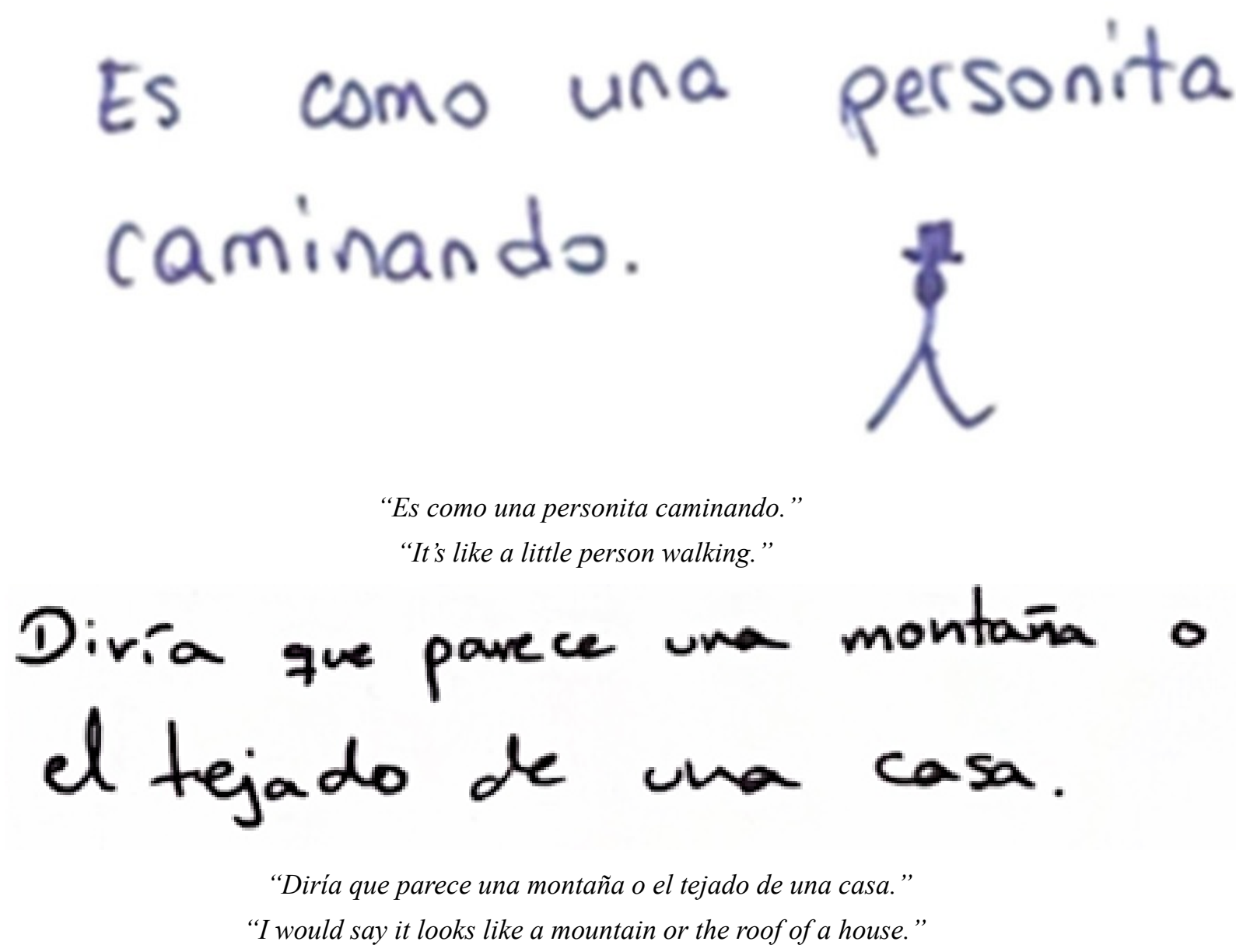
Results: learner interpretations across the Rén component family

象形
Pictographs
人

Perceptual level: the human figure is not fully transparent.

Explanatory level: learners may construct interpretations that approach the traditional pictographic rationale.

Examples: “Es como una personita caminando.” vs. “una montaña / el tejado de una casa”.



会意与指事
Ideographic compounds and simple indicatives
休 / 仙 / 会 / 今

From ideographic compounds to simple indicatives, the learners’ reliance on cognitive resources appears to shift from graphic cues to semantic integration, and further toward cultural association.

Key pattern: interpretation moves from graphic cues to semantic integration and cultural association.



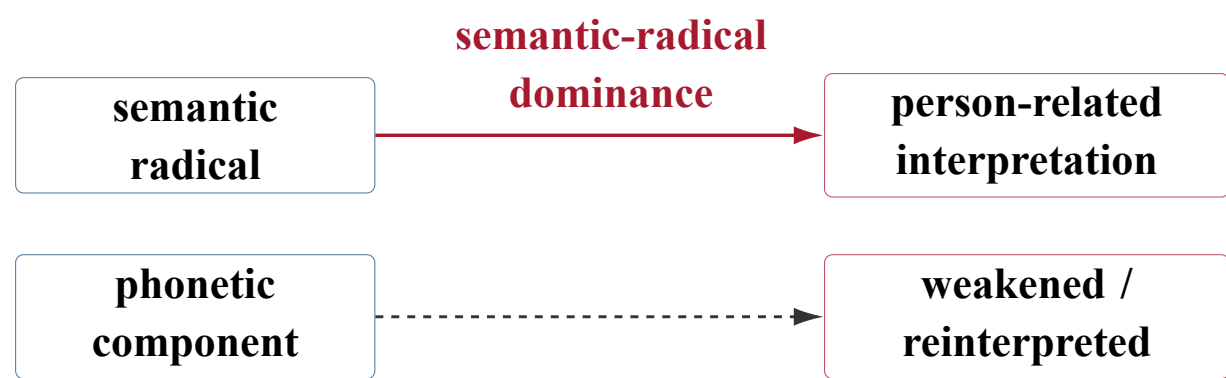
Character	Learner responses
休	“Persona descansa bajo el árbol.” “Person resting under a tree.”
仙	“Persona, montaña, gallego.” “Person, mountain, Galician.”
会	“Superman¿?” “Superman?”
今	“Representa el presente en el cual se encuentra la persona.” “The present moment in which the person is located.”

Learner responses illustrating semantic integration and cultural association.

形声
Phono-semantic compounds
你 / 什 / 伙

In phono-semantic characters with 亻, learners tended to privilege the person-related semantic component, while the phonetic component was weakened, ignored, or semantically reinterpreted.

Key pattern: learners interpret phono-semantic characters through semantic-radical dominance rather than full phono-semantic decomposition.



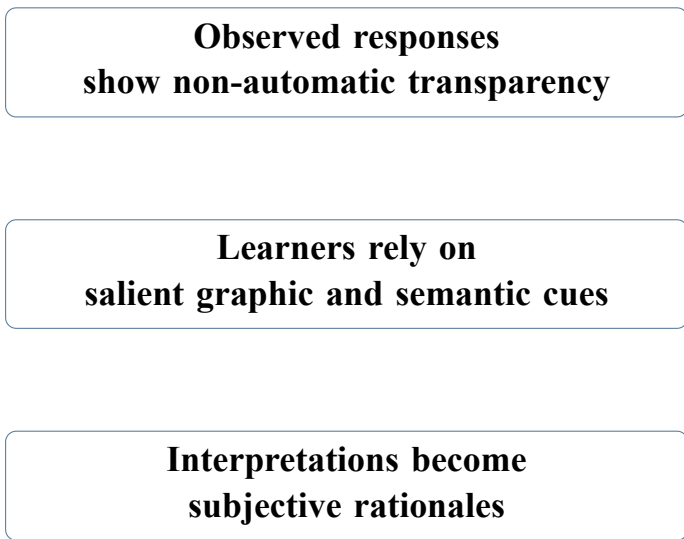
Learner responses to characters with 亻 (persona) emerges as the dominant association.

Objective character motivation ≠ Learner interpretation
From observed response patterns to a reconstruction model

Learners use graphic and semantic cues from the whole character or its components as triggers to activate associations and construct subjective rationales.

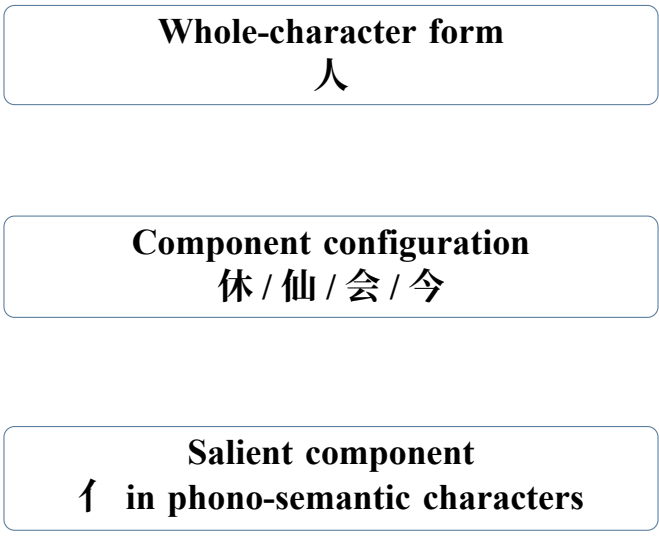
Conceptual mapping model: cue-triggered subjective reconstruction

From results to model



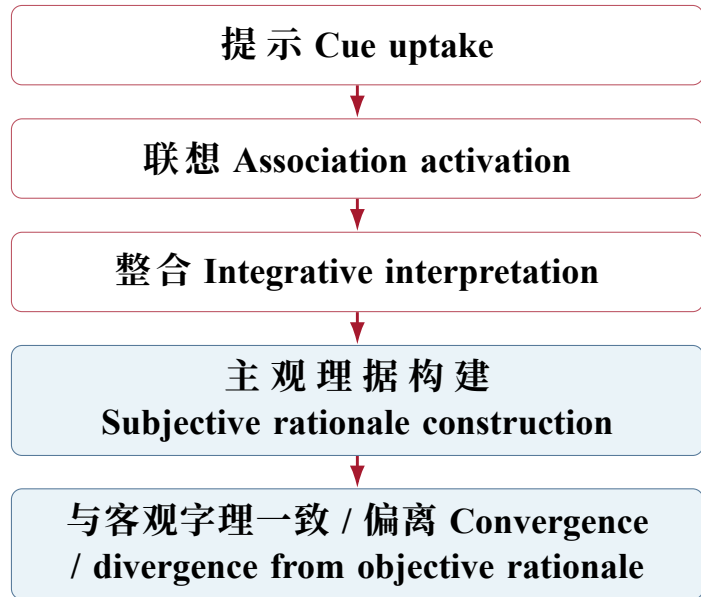
The model abstracts common patterns found across pictographic, ideographic, and phono-semantic cases.

Empirical triggers



Whole-character form, component configuration, and salient radicals provide the cues that initiate learner interpretation.

Cognitive operations



Triggers are processed through cue uptake, association, and integration.

The model explains how learners transform visual and semantic cues into subjective rationales for characters in the Rén component family.
Interpretations are constructed through cognitive operations, rather than directly read off from graphic form.

Mechanism and pedagogical implications

Mechanism explanation

- 1. Non-automatic transparency**
Objective character motivation does not automatically become learner-perceived motivation.
- 2. Cue-triggered reconstruction**
Learners use whole-character forms, component configurations, and salient radicals as triggers for interpretation.
- 3. Divergence through integration**
Limited cognitive resources and cultural experience may lead learners to integrate cues in ways that diverge from traditional rationale.

Teaching implications

- Do not treat etymology as self-evident.**
Learners’ subjective rationales can be used as a bridge toward more systematic explanations of character structure.
- Use subjective rationales as scaffolding.**
Learner associations can reveal how they process graphic form, establish form–meaning connections, and ultimately construct subjective rationales.
- Guide learners from association to structure.**
Teaching should use subjective rationales as a starting point while setting boundaries against arbitrary form–meaning interpretation.

Deviations are not merely errors, but outcomes of cognitive strategy selection.

Chinese character pedagogy should give greater attention to learners’ subjective rationale construction alongside the explanation of character structure.

References and supplement

- Xu, S. (1978). *Shuō wén jiě zì*. Zhonghua Shuju.
- Ruiz de Mendoza Ibáñez, F. J., & Masegosa, A. G. (2014). *Cognitive Modeling: A Linguistic Perspective*. John Benjamins.



Scan for poster PDF, references, and contact.